



Brookline

BROOKLINE COUNCIL ON AGING · BROOKLINE SENIOR CENTER

Aging in the Town of Brookline: A Community Needs Assessment — Executive Summary, July 2026

CRITICAL

HIGH PRIORITY

IMPORTANT

WHO WE ARE

Brookline's older adults, by the numbers

Brookline's population age 60 and older is sizeable and expected to keep growing. Based on U.S. Census data, the American Community Survey (2024), and UMass Donahue Institute projections.



21%

of Brookline's 63,266 residents are age 60+



24%

projected share age 60+ by 2040



13,222

residents age 60+ in 2020 (up from 10,816 in 2010)



42%

of respondents age 80+ live alone (vs. 25% of those in their 60s)



39%

of residents age 75+ report at least one disability

NOW VS. 2040

A growing older population

TODAY

13,222

residents age 60+ (2020)

21% of all residents



BY 2040

14,975+

residents age 60+ projected

24% of all residents

A larger older population means rising demand for the programs, services, and supports that help residents stay independent and connected to their community.

WHAT MATTERS MOST

Top concerns raised by residents



37%

wrote in about cost-of-living concerns — home maintenance, taxes, and utilities — as the top worry about staying in Brookline



41%

provided care or assistance to a disabled or frail person in the past 5 years



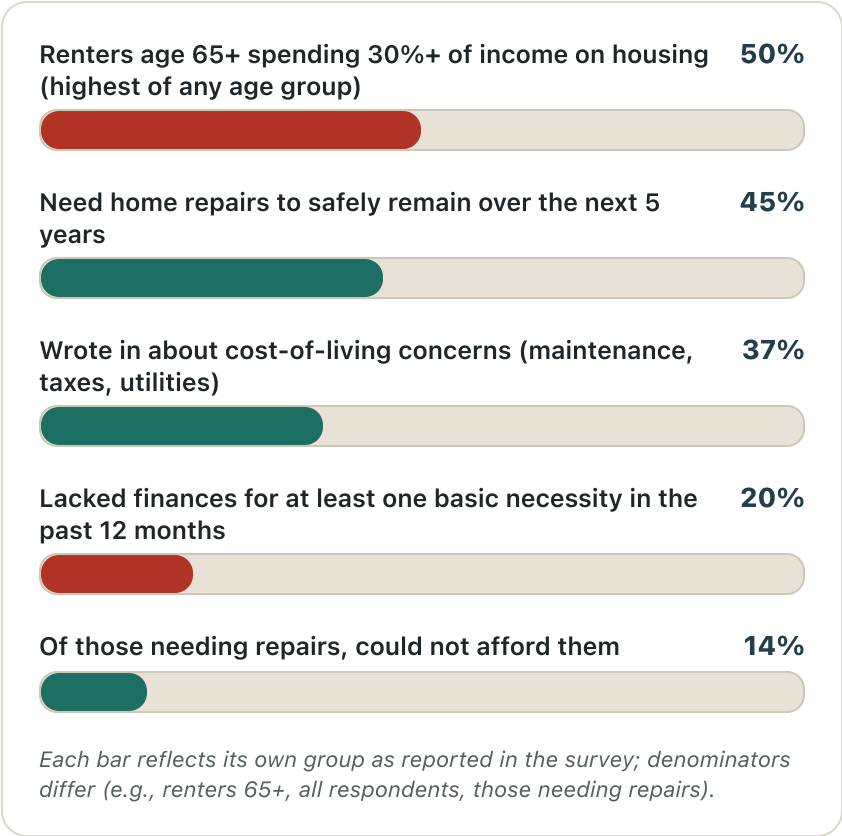
Nearly half

of respondents reported at least one transportation challenge

FINANCIAL PRESSURES

Financial insecurity & housing expenses

Financial insecurity, driven largely by taxes, is among the top concerns for older residents.



\$

Women living alone have a median income of just **\$57,500** — older adults living alone have substantially lower incomes.

Stakeholders described many residents as **"house rich but tax poor,"** warning that longtime residents may be priced out.

"Taxes are crushing us; cannot keep up with increases; falling behind on paying for services (water, trash, electric, heat expenses)"

— Brookline survey respondent

GETTING AROUND

Transportation & accessibility

Focus group participants repeatedly identified medical transportation as a core service that supports independence and aging in place — and voiced concern about reductions in it.

16%

of non-driving respondents missed, cancelled, or rescheduled a medical appointment because of transportation barriers

Nearly ½

of respondents reported at least one transportation challenge

Reductions in medical transportation services

Not enough subsidized rideshare or medical-transport rides

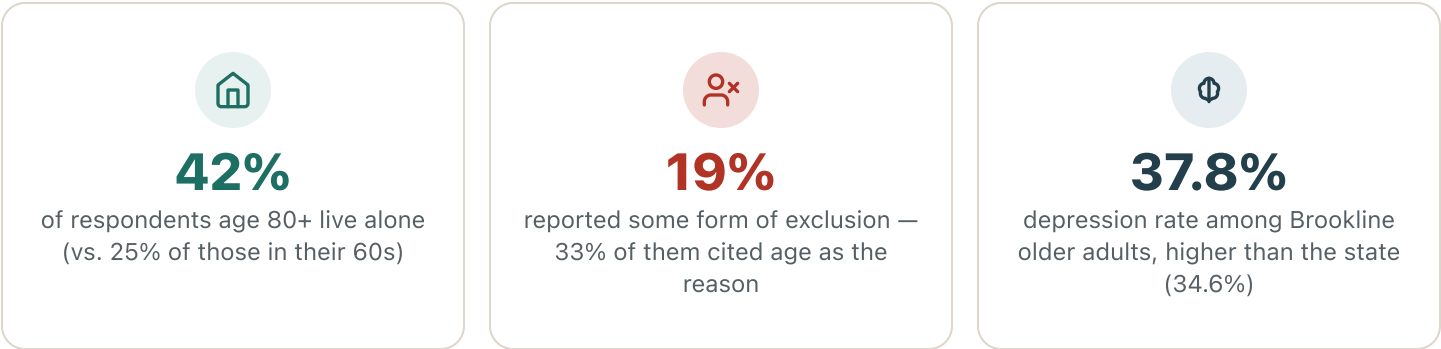
Unsafe sidewalks and winter conditions

Homes & community spaces hard to navigate with walkers/wheelchairs

SOCIAL CONNECTION

Social wellness & isolation

Older adults who live alone may especially benefit from programs and services that offer opportunities to connect in person.



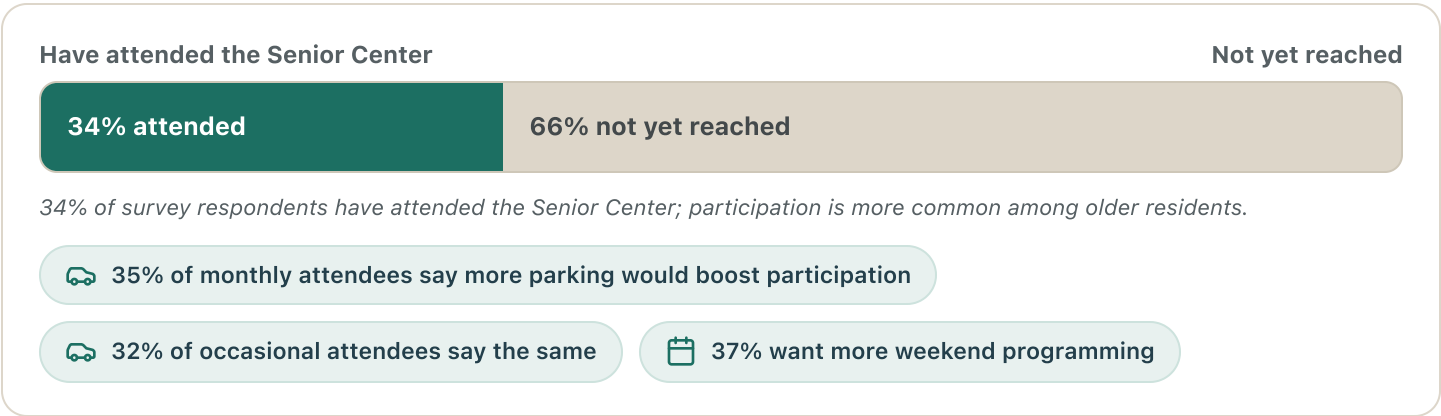
"Isolation. Since I live alone in my own house. Neighbors tend to be younger with busy lives. Older friends/neighbors are moving away, getting sick/dementia, etc. Can create 'loneliness'. Which makes having a great + accessible Senior Center so important."

— Brookline survey respondent

BROOKLINE SENIOR CENTER

An invaluable resource — at capacity

Residents want the Brookline Senior Center to keep expanding options for participation, but its capacity to serve the diverse needs of older residents is limited.



Opened in **2001**, when about **9,028** residents were 60+ — compared with about **13,347** residents 60+ in 2024.

Strong interest in expanded **educational, cultural, and wellness** programming, pointing to demand for more space.

"Senior center is too small for the number of elderly who live in Brookline... Space is inadequate. A much larger building is needed with parking!"

— Brookline survey respondent

The strain on family caregivers

Older residents experience changing physical and psychological conditions, and caregivers to older adults need help managing this care.



41%

of respondents provided care or assistance to a disabled or frail person in the past 5 years



50%

of caregivers are ages 60–69 — the largest share of any cohort, suggesting many are part of the "sandwich" generation



57%

of caregivers found it somewhat or very challenging to balance with other responsibilities

Approximately 1 in 5 caregivers reported declines in any of the following due to caregiving:



Physical health



Mental health



Social life

THE PATH FORWARD

7 priorities for action

Strategic recommendations for the Town of Brookline and the Council on Aging to address the needs of the town's aging population.



CRITICAL

Financial security & tax relief

Continue reviewing and expanding property tax relief programs to help older homeowners remain in their homes.

50% of renters 65+ housing cost-burdened



CRITICAL

Outreach & in-home support for 80+

Prioritize outreach and in-home supports for adults 80 and older, especially those living alone or without nearby family.

42% of respondents 80+ live alone



CRITICAL

Restore & expand transportation

Prioritize restoring and expanding transportation services that help older adults reach healthcare appointments.

16% of non-drivers missed medical care



HIGH PRIORITY

Expand caregiver support

Expand support for family caregivers and reach "younger older adults" who would benefit from caregiving support.

41% are caregivers; 57% find it hard



HIGH PRIORITY

Accessibility & Age-Friendly design

Review municipal facilities and public spaces, and embed Age-Friendly principles across all departments and boards.

39% of residents 75+ report a disability



HIGH PRIORITY

Long-term facilities strategy

Develop a long-term strategy — renovation, expansion, or satellite service models — so more residents can be served.

Only 34% have ever attended



IMPORTANT

Coordinated communications hub

Reposition the Senior Center as a central hub for information using print, digital, and telephone outreach.

55% of non-attendees want more info

If these recommendations are implemented



Longtime residents stay in their homes.

Expanded property tax relief helps older homeowners remain, while easing pressure on the half of renters 65+ who are cost-burdened.



Isolated older adults get connected.

Targeted outreach reaches the 42% of respondents age 80+ who live alone.



Fewer missed medical appointments.

Restored transportation supports the 16% of non-driving respondents who had to skip or reschedule care.



Caregivers get relief.

New supports reach the 41% of residents who provide care — and the 57% who find it challenging.



A Senior Center that fits the community.

A facilities strategy addresses a Center built when 9,028 residents were 60+, now serving about 13,347.



More residents find their way in.

Coordinated outreach engages the 55% of non-attendees who simply want to know what's offered.



In conclusion

Brookline's older population will keep expanding, and demand for supportive services will rise alongside it. Acting on these priorities lets the town lean into the strengths it already has while directing attention and resources to where older residents need them most.

"Brookline is great and could do so much more. The few times I have visited the Senior Center to see what is offered I have felt like I entered an assisted living facility."

— Brookline survey respondent